

dance

Globalisation has not just opened doors for Indians—foreigners too are stepping into the world of *mudras* and *taals*, and becoming a part of it. Cable television and MTV ensured a generation of Indian hip hoppers and salsa swingers, but influx of tourists into India, as well as the impact of ‘cultural’ exports abroad, has signalled a reverse trend. And Delhi, in this respect,

seems to be that melting pot of nationalities and culture as many foreign students, especially women, arrive here to learn different Indian dance forms. While some stay on and teach, others master the art and take it back to their countries. What is common to both, though, is their passion to learn. SIMPLY DELHI finds out what fascinates these expat women to come here, all the way from their respective homelands.

Take Suvdaa Lkhagvasuren from Mongolia, for instance. She was so

determined to come to India, that she first learnt Hindi for two years from the Indian embassy in her country. She got hold of an Indian music video and taught herself the dance steps. “I made a video on the song and sent it to the Indian Council for Cultural Relations (ICCR). They saw my videos and offered me a course in Bharatanatyam, two years ago,” says Lkhagvasuren. The next thing she would like to try is Hindustani classical vocal music and Odissi dance. “If I do

THESE EXPATS HAVE MADE DELHI THEIR HOME AND FOUND THEIR TRUE

CULTURE curry

CALLING IN LEARNING INDIAN DANCE FORMS



VIRAM SHARMA

If I do well here, I would like to take my skills back to Mongolia and teach there. Imagine, I will be the only one in Mongolia to be teaching an Indian dance!

SUVDAA LKHAGVASUREN,
Mongolia

well here, I would like to go back to Mongolia and teach there.

Another expat drawn to India for classical dance is Natalia Ivanova, a flamenco dancer who's been learning under Kathak exponent Perna Shrimali for the past 10 years. “What sets Indian dance apart is the ‘abhinaya’ aspect—the fact that the lyrics of the song are beautifully expressed through dance,” says Ivanova. To express the poetry through movements, one needs more than just technical skills. One needs to transform oneself into another character to make the performance look real. But that's a lot of hard work for someone who is not of Indian origin.

She says her life changed completely when she saw a performance